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Jonah

Jonah 1:1

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:1

Now the word of the LORD came to Jonah son of Amittai, saying,

- ¶ One day Yahweh gave this command to Jonah, son of Amittai,
- ¶ There was a man in Israel named Jonah, who was the son of Amittai. One day Yahweh said to him,

Now the word of the LORD came to Jonah son of Amittai, saying:

The expression the word of the LORD came to Jonah refers to the message which the LORD communicated to Jonah. We do not know how Jonah received this message. It could have been in a vision or a dream, or perhaps the LORD spoke directly to him.

In Hebrew the story begins abruptly: the word of the LORD came to Jonah. Most English versions follow the Hebrew style. However, in your language it may be necessary to reorder the verse so that the story begins in a more natural way for your readers. Notice that the second meaning line in the Display gives one possible way of doing this. You need to decide which is the best way in your language for introducing this story.

LORD: LORD represents the Hebrew Yahweh, the personal name of God. See the notes in the Introduction on how to translate this term.

Jonah son of Amittai: Jonah was the son of a man called Amittai. Nothing more is recorded about Jonah's background in this book. 2 Kings 14:25 gives a little more information. The important thing to keep in mind is that he was an Israelite and the LORD told him to deliver a message to the people of Nineveh, who were enemies of the Israelites. In the New Testament, Jesus referred to Jonah as a prophet (Matthew 12:29).

Jonah 1:2

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction

to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:2a

“Get up! Go to the great city of Nineveh

- “Go at once to the large city of/called Nineveh

Get up! Go to the great city of Nineveh: Nineveh is called a great city because it was very large and many people lived in it. It was so large that it took a person three days to walk through it (3:3). More than 120,000 people lived there (4:11).

Get up! Go to...Nineveh: In Hebrew this verse begins with two verbs *qum* and *leḵ* which literally mean “arise, go.” Some English versions retain the two verbs. For example:

Arise, go to Nineveh (RSV)

However, when the verb *qum* is followed by another motion verb, many scholars believe that it has lost its literal meaning and that instead it signals the beginning of an action. In this case it may also signal the urgency of the action. In English versions, you will see this combination of verbs translated in three different ways:

1. “Leave at once for Nineveh” (GW) or “Go at once to Nineveh” (NJPS, NRSV). The translators of these versions express the force of *qum* by the words “at once.” Other ways of doing this in English would be to begin the verse “Start on your way” or “Get going.”
2. The verb *qum* is not translated at all and the verse is translated as Go to...Nineveh (NIV, GNT, CEV).
3. The verb *qum* is translated literally: “arise” or “get up” (BSB, KJV, NCV, NJB, NLT, RSV).

The third option should be avoided because it gives the impression that the LORD was telling Jonah to do two things: “get up” and “go.” It is recommended that you follow one of the translation possibilities suggested in option 1.

1:2b

and preach against it,

- and preach my message against the people there
- and confront the people there with my message of judgment

and preach against it: The rest of the story shows that what Jonah was told to speak was a message which condemned the people of Nineveh (Keil-Delitzsch, p.

389). Some translations make this explicit. For example:

cry out against it (NRSV)

go now and denounce it (REB)

speak against it (TEV)

it: This refers to the city of Nineveh. Although the text says that Jonah was to preach against “the city of Nineveh,” it meant that he was to preach against the people of the city because of the wicked way they were behaving.

1:2c

because its wickedness has come up before Me.”

- for it has come to my notice how very wicked they are.”
- for I know how very wicked they are.”

its wickedness: Here the wickedness and sinful behavior of the people of Nineveh is referred to as if the city were a person.

has come up before Me: Or “has come to my attention.” The LORD knew how very sinful the people of Nineveh were. Here is another way to express this idea:

I am aware of how wicked its people are (GNT)

Jonah 1:3

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD’s command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:3a

Jonah, however, got up to flee to Tarshish, away from the presence of the LORD.

- ¶ But Jonah refused to go to Nineveh. Instead he tried to flee from Yahweh and started off in the other direction for Tarshish.

Jonah, however: Other versions say “But Jonah.” This verse clearly contrasts with verse 2. The LORD had told Jonah to do one thing, but Jonah had decided to do something completely different.

got up to flee to Tarshish, away from the presence of the LORD: As an Israelite, Jonah knew that the LORD was everywhere—yet he tried to flee from his presence. So in what sense could he flee from the LORD? Perhaps he thought that by leaving Israel, the country where the LORD’s temple was, and going far away to a country where the people did not follow the LORD, there would be less chance that the LORD would bother him with the command to preach to the people of Nineveh.

to flee to Tarshish: One thing is certain: Jonah had no intention of obeying the LORD or of going to Nineveh. Instead, he went in the opposite direction, towards the city of Tarshish. This was probably in the country now known as Spain. In Jonah’s time, it was considered to be at the western end of the world. Nineveh, however, was northeast of Israel. Jonah wanted to get as far away from Nineveh and its people as possible, since he did not want to give the LORD’s message to them.

1:3b

He went down to Joppa and found a ship bound for Tarshish.

- He went to Joppa a city on the sea coast. There he found a ship about to depart for Tarshish.

He went down to Joppa: Joppa was a city in Israel on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea. Ships would stop there to pick up passengers and cargo.

went down: Jonah went from higher land down to the coast.

and found a ship bound for Tarshish: There in Joppa, Jonah found a ship which was ready to sail to Tarshish. The sailors (the men who worked on the ship) were not Israelites but were probably from the country of Phoenicia (Clarke, p. 702; Ellison, p. 370).

1:3c

So he paid the fare

- After he/Jonah had paid the fare,

So he paid the fare: The text does not tell us to whom Jonah paid the money. If it is necessary in your language to supply this information, you could say, “to the owner of the boat.”

fare: This refers to the money Jonah paid to travel on the ship.

1:3d

and went aboard to sail for Tarshish,

- he got on it to go with the sailors to Tarshish,

and went aboard to sail for Tarshish: The RSV has: “to go with them to Tarshish.” Most commentators agree

that “with them” (omitted by the BSB) refers to the sailors. For example:

went aboard with the crew to sail to Spain (GNT)

However, the GNT makes it sound like Jonah and the sailors got on the ship together, that is, at the same time. This may be confusing, since the crew were probably already on the ship.

1:3e

away from the presence of the LORD.

- for he was trying to run away from Yahweh.

away from the presence of the LORD: This is the second time this expression has occurred in this verse. See note on 1:3a. The phrase is probably repeated to emphasize it. Most English versions repeat the phrase as the Hebrew text does, although they use different words. For example, compare 1:3a and 1:3e in the CEV.

Jonah 1:4

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD’s command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:4a

Then the LORD hurled a great wind upon the sea,

- ¶ Then Yahweh sent a strong wind on the sea.
- ¶ Then Yahweh caused a strong wind to blow on the sea.

Then the LORD hurled a great wind upon the sea:

The Israelites believed that the winds were the LORD’s servants (see Psalm 104:4). The image of hurling wind may not be clear or natural in your language. Decide what would be the best verb to use in your language: could the LORD “hurl” the wind, “send” it, or “cause” it to blow? If possible, use a term which expresses how violent and sudden the action was. For example:

the Lord sent a great wind (NIV)

the Lord flung a powerful wind (NLT96)

1:4b

and such a violent storm arose that the ship was in danger of breaking apart.

- This became a terrible storm, with the waves hitting the ship with such force that the ship was about to break into pieces.
- This caused a terrible storm, and the waves threatened to break the ship in pieces.

and such a violent storm arose that the ship was in danger of breaking apart: As a result of the strong wind, a fierce storm developed. The waves started to hit against the ship with great force, and the ship was about to break into pieces. It may be necessary in your language to include the information about the waves to explain how the storm affected the boat.

a violent storm: The Hebrew word which the BSB translates as violent means “great.” You should choose the most natural word in your language to describe a severe storm.

Jonah 1:5

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD’s command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:5a

The sailors were afraid,

- Therefore all the sailors were afraid

1:5b

and each cried out to his own god.

- and each of them called loudly to his own god to save them.
- and each of them prayed earnestly to his own god to rescue them.

each cried out to his own god: The sailors were aware that unless some god helped them, the ship would sink, and they would all die. So because they were afraid, each of them called to the particular god he believed in to help/rescue them.

his own god: In Jonah, there is a distinction made between “God”—that is, the LORD—and “god/gods.” Notice that the letter “g” in the English spelling of god in this verse is not capitalized. This shows that it is not the LORD, the true God, who is being referred to here. It is possible that these sailors were from different nations and each nationality had its own gods. However, it is more likely that these sailors were all Phoenicians (Ellison p. 370), who believed in many different gods.

1:5c

And they threw the ship's cargo into the sea to lighten the load.

- Then they threw the cargo into the sea to make the ship lighter and try to keep it from sinking.

And they threw the ship's cargo into the sea to lighten the load: As well as praying to their gods to rescue them, they did their best to help the ship remain floating. A heavy ship floats lower in the water than a light ship and therefore has a greater chance of water splashing into it and causing the ship to sink. Therefore, the sailors threw the cargo overboard to make it lighter.

the ship's cargo: If you do not have a term for cargo in your language, you could say "the things the ship was carrying."

1:5d

But Jonah had gone down to the lowest part of the vessel, where he lay down and fell into a deep sleep.

- But as for Jonah, he had earlier gone down into the bottom part of the ship. There he had lain down and was now sleeping deeply.

But Jonah had gone down to the lowest part of the vessel, where he lay down and fell into a deep sleep: It is not clear whether Jonah went down into the hold of the ship and went to sleep before the storm started or during it. Many English versions retain this ambiguity. Other versions make it clear that it was before the storm. For example:

All this time, Jonah was down below deck, sound asleep (CEV)

Most other versions use the connecting word "Meanwhile," which also makes it clear that Jonah had gone to sleep before the storm. It is recommended that you follow this interpretation.

Jonah 1:6

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:6a

The captain approached him and said,

- The captain of the ship went to him and said,
- The captain found him there sleeping, woke him, and said,

The captain approached him: The captain of the ship, that is, the man who was in charge of the ship, found Jonah asleep and was surprised. Although it is possible that the captain had gone looking for Jonah, most commentators consider it more likely that he just noticed Jonah asleep when he went down into the ship for some other reason, perhaps to get some more cargo to throw into the sea.

1:6b

"How can you sleep?"

- "How can you^(sing) sleep at a time like this?"
- You^(sing) should not be sleeping at a time like this.

How can you sleep?: His question to Jonah was not a real question, but a rhetorical one. He was scolding Jonah for being asleep when he should have been praying to his god for help. If rhetorical questions cannot be used in your language for scolding, you may need to use a statement here instead of a question.

1:6c

Get up and call upon your God.

- Get up and pray fervently to your god for help!

Get up and call upon your God: The captain ordered Jonah to pray fervently to his god for help. Notice BSB uses God with a capital "G" because it refers to the true God even though the captain did not yet know that Jonah's god was the true God. However, since the captain did not know this he probably talked about him as if he were just one of many gods. Other versions do not capitalize "god" here (NIV, NET, NRSV, ESV, etc).

Notice that *qum* here has its normal meaning of "get up" although the construction is similar to 1:2a. Jonah was lying down, so it is natural that the captain should tell him to Get up. So it should be translated as a separate verb.

1:6d

Perhaps this God will consider us, so that we may not perish."

- If you^(sing) do, then he might take pity on us^(incl) and save/rescue us from drowning/death."
- Perhaps he will spare us^(incl) so that we will not die/drown."

Perhaps this God will consider us, so that we may not perish: The people from the nations near Israel believed that storms were caused and controlled by various gods and that they had the power to stop or

even start storms. Therefore, the captain felt that it was very important that everyone on the ship ought to be praying to their gods so the people on board the ship would be spared and not die.

Jonah 1:7

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:7a

“Come!” said the sailors to one another.

- ¶ Then the sailors said to each other,

1:7b

“Let us cast lots to find out who is responsible for this calamity that is upon us.”

- “We^(incl) must cast lots to find out who is to blame for our trouble.”
- “Let us^(incl) cast lots to show us whose fault it is that we are in danger.”

1:7a–b

“Come!” said the sailors to one another. “Let us cast lots to find out who is responsible for this calamity that is upon us.”: There is a jump in the narrative at this point. The BSB just moves to the next action but in your language it may be necessary to fill in some of the missing steps. Between 1:6 and 1:7, the sailors had noticed that their prayers did not seem to be working. Also, the captain and Jonah had had time to get back to the deck of the ship. Decide whether you need to make any of these steps explicit in your translation.

“Come!”...“Let us cast lots to find out who is responsible for this calamity that is upon us.”: As the situation became more dangerous and their prayers didn't work, the sailors decided that the storm had happened because someone on the ship had done something to offend one of the gods. So they decided to cast lots to find out who the guilty person was.

“Come!”: You should probably not translate this literally. The Hebrew word here has the sense in English of “come on, let us do something.” GNT and NJPS just omit it.

cast lots: People often cast lots to determine the cause of events which puzzle them. The way the lots were actually cast on this occasion is not known.

Perhaps the sailors threw dice or drew straws. Another possibility is that each person's name was written on small tablets or pieces of wood. One of these tablets was then picked at random. The person whose name was on the chosen tablet would be the person who was at fault. You should try, if possible, to use an expression which does not identify a particular method of casting lots.

1:7c

So they cast lots, and the lot fell on Jonah.

- So they cast lots, and the lot which was chosen indicated that Jonah was at fault.
- So they cast lots, and Jonah was the one chosen by the lot.

the lot fell on Jonah: Jonah was picked out by lot. This proved to the others on the ship that he was the one responsible for the storm, or at least that he knew something about why it had happened.

Jonah 1:8

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:8a

“Tell us now,” they demanded, “who is to blame for this calamity that is upon us?”

- So they asked him, “Tell us^(excl), who is the one who is to blame for all our^(incl) trouble?”

who is to blame for this calamity that is upon us?: It is not entirely clear why the sailors should have asked this question when the lot had already proven that Jonah was to blame. So some English versions have reworded the question. For example, the NRSV asks the reason for the storm: “Tell us why this calamity has come upon us.” However, the way the BSB (as well as the NIV, GNT, RSV, CEV, KJV, NCV) has translated it is the clearest way of understanding the Hebrew, so you should follow these versions. Perhaps the sailors wanted Jonah to admit his guilt himself, so they could be certain it was his fault.

1:8b

What is your occupation,

- What is your job/occupation?
- What do you^(sing) do for a living?

What is your occupation: There are two possible interpretations of this question:

1. The sailors wanted to know what Jonah's occupation was. This seems to be the clearest meaning of the Hebrew word *mela'kah* and is probably how this should be translated. The main difficulty is why the sailors should have been interested in Jonah's occupation at all. It has been suggested that they thought it was possible that his occupation may have been one which would have caused the gods to be angry.¹⁸ Keil-Delitzsch, p. 395. (BSB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, KJV, NCV, NLT)
2. The sailors wanted to know what was Jonah's purpose or reason for traveling on the ship. This fits the context well, but is not the most natural understanding of the Hebrew. (TEV, NJB, NJPS, REB)¹⁸ Allen, p. 206; Ellison, p. 372; Sasson, p. 107

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1).

1:8c

and where have you come from? What is your country,

- Where are you^(sing) from? And what is your native country?
- What country do you^(sing) come from?

and where have you come from? What is your country: This would appear to be the same question expressed in two different ways. The GNT translates this as a single question:

What country do you come from? (GNT, see also NLT)

However, these two questions could reflect the many questions the sailors were asking Jonah. If you think this is the case, you may want to keep both questions. You need to decide which is most natural in your language, that is, to keep both questions as the BSB has done, or to combine these two sentences into one as the GNT and NLT have done.

1:8d

and who are your people?"

- To which ethnic group do you^(sing) belong?"

and who are your people?: Here the sailors wanted to know what ethnic group Jonah was from. Perhaps it was clear from his speech or appearance that he was a foreigner to them. This was important to them because different ethnic groups usually worshiped different gods.

Jonah 1:9

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:9a

"I am a Hebrew," replied Jonah.

- Jonah answered them, "I am a Hebrew,
- Jonah replied, "I am from the people called Hebrews,

"I am a Hebrew,": Jonah only answered the final question. By this statement, he made it clear he was a foreigner to the sailors.

Hebrew: This was the term other people used when they referred to the Israelites. The Israelites themselves often used it when they spoke about themselves to foreigners. You should probably transliterate the word Hebrew here to distinguish it from your translation of the term "Israelite."

1:9b

"I worship the LORD, the God of the heavens,

- and it is Yahweh, the God in heaven, whom I worship.
- and I worship Yahweh, the God in heaven.

I worship the LORD: The Hebrew verb which the BSB translates as worship is literally "fear" (same verb as in 1:5a). The OT often uses the verb "to fear" when referring to people's relationship to God. In such a context, this verb is sometimes translated "stand in awe of" but worship makes better sense here.

LORD: See the statement on Yahweh in the Introduction. By using God's special name, Jonah was distinguishing the true God whom he worshiped from the various "gods" whom the sailors worshiped.

the God of the heavens: Jonah described God as the God of the heavens. Here of refers to where God was thought to live. It can be translated "the God in the heavens."

In the Hebrew text, the expression "the LORD, the God of heaven" occurs at the beginning of the sentence (not its normal place) for emphasis. We could translate this emphasis in English as

"It is the LORD, the God of heaven, whom I worship."

1:9c**who made the sea and the dry land.”**

- He is the one who created/made the sea and the land.”
- He is the creator/maker of the sea and the land.”

who made the sea and the dry land: By saying that the LORD was the creator of the sea and the dry land, Jonah implied that the LORD controlled these areas and therefore the terrible storm as well.

the sea and the dry land: This means “the whole world.”

Jonah 1:10

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed This section tells about the LORD’s command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:10a**The men knew that he was fleeing from the presence of the LORD, because he had told them.**

- Then Jonah told them he was fleeing from Yahweh so that he would not have to do what Yahweh had commanded him to do.

The men knew that he was fleeing from the presence of the LORD, because he had told them: Here the author gives the reason why the sailors were terrified, that is, because Jonah had told them that he was running away from the LORD. In the BSB, the result (they were even more afraid) is given first and then the reason (Jonah had told them he was running away from the LORD) is given. In the Display this has been reordered and the reason given first. Consider if it is more natural in your language to place the reason first or last.

1:10**Then the men were even more afraid and said to him, “What have you done?” The men knew that he was fleeing from the presence of the LORD, because he had told them.****1:10b****Then the men were even more afraid**

- When they heard this, they were terrified,
- When they heard what Jonah told them, they became even more afraid

Then the men were even more afraid: The expression translated even more afraid is literally “they were afraid with a great fear.” 1:5 said that they were afraid; now their fear had increased.

1:10c**and said to him, “What have you done?”**

- and they replied, “That’s terrible! How could you^(sing) dare to do that?”
- and said, “What you^(sing) have done is terrible!”

What have you done?: This is another rhetorical question. It showed that the sailors were terrified because Jonah had disobeyed God (Ellison, p. 372; Keil-Delitzsch, pp. 395–96).

If your language does not use rhetorical questions often or does not use them to blame someone for something, you will need to express the question as a statement. For example, see the second meaning line in 1:10c in the Display.

Jonah 1:11**Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed**

This section tells about the LORD’s command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:11a**Now the sea was growing worse and worse,**

- ¶ The storm was becoming worse and worse, and the sea was becoming rougher.
- ¶ As they were speaking, the storm was becoming worse and worse, and the waves were becoming bigger.

Now the sea was growing worse and worse: All the time the sailors were talking to Jonah the sea grew rougher. The Hebrew idiom used here has the sense of “more and more,” that is, “the sea continued to get rougher.”

1:11b**so they said to Jonah, “What must we do to you to calm this sea for us?”**

- So the sailors asked Jonah, “What should we^(excl) do to you^(sing) to calm the sea?”
- So they asked him, “What should we^(excl) do to you^(sing) to make the storm stop?”

What must we do to you to calm this sea for us?: Now that the sailors knew that the storm had hap-

pened because Jonah had disobeyed the LORD, they asked Jonah what they should do to him to make it stop. They felt that they needed to punish him so they could be rescued from the storm.

Jonah 1:12

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:12a

“Pick me up,” he answered, “and cast me into the sea, so it may quiet down for you.

- Jonah answered them, “Take hold of me and throw me into the sea. Then the storm will stop.

Pick me up...and cast me into the sea: You may not need to use both the verbs Pick...up and cast in your language. For example:

Throw me into the sea (GNT)

The Hebrew verb which the BSB has translated cast is the same word used in 1:5c for throwing the cargo into the sea. It is also the same word used for the LORD's action of “hurling” the wind in 1:4a.

1:12b

For I know that I am to blame for this violent storm that has come upon you.”

- I know that it is my fault that you^(plur) are caught in this terrible storm.”
- I know that I am to blame for this terrible storm that you^(plur) are in.”

For I know that I am to blame for this violent storm that has come upon you: Jonah knew that the storm had happened because he had disobeyed the LORD.

General Comment about 1:12

In your language you may need to reorder the parts of this verse to show more clearly how they relate to one another. For example,

Jonah answered them, “I know that it is because of me that you (plur) are in this terrible storm. So take hold of me and throw me into the sea. If you (plur) do that, then it will become calm.”

Jonah 1:13

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:13a

Nevertheless, the men rowed hard to get back to dry land,

- ¶ However, the men did not want to throw Jonah overboard, so they tried hard to row the ship back to land.
- ¶ Instead of doing what Jonah said, the sailors made a great effort to get the ship back to land.

Nevertheless, the men rowed hard to get back to dry land: At first the sailors did not want to throw Jonah overboard. Instead they tried to save themselves and Jonah by rowing back to land. But this was not possible because the storm and the sea grew more violent.

rowed hard to get back: The Hebrew verb used here literally means “to dig” and gives the impression of effort in their rowing. BSB expresses this by rowed hard. Here is another way to express the effort:

with all their might (GNT)

If you have no word in your language for “row,” a possibility might be “worked hard to make the boat get back to land.”

1:13b

but they could not,

- But they were not able to do this,

1:13c

for the sea was raging against them more and more.

- for the waves of the sea were now bigger than before.
- for the storm was now worse than before.

for the sea was raging against them more and more: This is the same Hebrew idiom as in 1:11a. See the note there.

Jonah 1:14

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:14a

So they cried out to the LORD:

- Then they prayed earnestly to Yahweh, and said,
- Then they called loudly to Yahweh,

So they cried out to the LORD: This is the first time the sailors prayed to the LORD, the true God, instead of to their own gods.

1:14b

“Please, O LORD, do not let us perish on account of this man’s life!

- “O Yahweh, we^(excl) need to kill this man, but we plead with you^(sing) not to cause us to die for doing it.
- “Please do not make us^(excl) die because we kill this man, O Yahweh.

Please, O LORD, do not let us perish on account of this man’s life: When the sailors became sure that they could not save themselves, they decided that they must kill Jonah by throwing him into the sea. However, they wanted to make sure that the LORD would not punish them for killing Jonah, so they asked to be forgiven even before doing it.

Please: This translates a word in Hebrew which indicates that what follows is a plea or entreaty. It is sometimes translated in older English translations as “we beseech you.” If there is a word or phrase in your language which is used in a situation where someone is begging another person to do something for them, you can use it here.

1:14c

Do not charge us with innocent blood!

- We^(excl) beg you^(sing), do not punish us if we are killing an innocent man.

Do not charge us with innocent blood: The GNT does not translate the word innocent. Instead, it combines this sentence with 1:14b, since it considers 1:14b–c as a doublet. However, most other English versions make a difference between 1:14b and 1:14c, and it is recommended that you do so too.

There are two ways to understand this statement:

1. The sailors were saying that there was a slight chance that Jonah might be innocent. (BSB, NIV, CEV, GW, KJV, NJPS, NJB, REB RSV).
2. The sailors were saying that Jonah was guilty. (NCV, NLT)

Although option 2 makes some sense in the context (since Jonah had admitted his guilt), most major commentaries and English versions support the first interpretation (1). It is recommended that you follow the first option too and translate this part of the verse in a way that makes it clear that the sailors still thought that Jonah might be innocent.

1:14d

For You, O LORD, have done as You pleased.”

- For, O Yahweh, it is you^(sing) who have caused all of this to happen according to your will.”

For You, O LORD, have done as You pleased: In the sailors’ minds, the LORD was responsible for the whole situation. He had sent the storm and he had indicated through the casting of lots that Jonah was the guilty party. Therefore he was also responsible for them needing to throw Jonah overboard. Therefore they asked the LORD not to blame them for Jonah’s death.

Jonah 1:15

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:15a

At this, they picked up Jonah and cast him into the sea,

- Then they took hold of Jonah and threw him out of the ship into the sea.

they picked up Jonah and cast him into the sea: The verbs translated picked up and cast are the same verbs which the BSB translated “pick up” and “cast” in 1:12a. See the note there.

1:15b

and the raging sea grew calm.

- Then the storm stopped and the raging sea became calm at once.
- The big waves in the sea became small again.

and the raging sea grew calm: This is a dramatic point in the story. The sailors' reaction in 1:16 shows this. The GNT uses a phrase to indicate this:

at once (GNT)

raging: As the English word raging used by the BSB suggests, the Hebrew word is connected with "anger." You will need to check whether or not you can use a similar image in your language.

Jonah 1:16

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

1:16a

Then the men feared the LORD greatly,

- This event made the men very afraid of Yahweh.
- When the men on the ship saw what happened, they became very afraid of Yahweh.

Then the men feared the LORD greatly: The storm stopped suddenly and the sea became calm. This showed the sailors that it was the LORD who controlled the storm. As a result, they feared him greatly. The Hebrew verb *yara'* can mean "to fear" or "to stand in awe of." With God as the object, it can also mean "to worship," as it did in 1:9. However, while any of these meanings are possible here, the majority of English versions understand it to mean "fear" or even "terrified." The addition of the expression "with a great fear" in the Hebrew text here also suggests that "fear" is the correct meaning.

1:16b

and they offered a sacrifice to the LORD

- So they offered a sacrifice to him
- So they killed an animal as a sacrifice to Yahweh

they offered a sacrifice to the LORD: We are not given any details about what kind of sacrifice the sailors made or how it was done. However, the Hebrew verb used here, when it refers to literal sacrifices, is always used in the OT for sacrificing an animal. So they probably killed an animal.

1:16c

and made vows to Him.

- and made all sorts of promises to him.

- and promised Yahweh that they would do something for him.

made vows to Him: We also do not know what the sailors promised in their vows. They probably promised to be loyal or faithful to the LORD in some way. They may have promised him that they would do something which they felt would please him, or they may have promised to give him another offering once they were safely back to land^{1.16} (Keil-Delitzsch, p. 397). Try not to translate in a way that indicates they promised to obey God, since it is unclear what vows they made. You should make your translation as general as possible.

Jonah 1:17

Section 1:1–17: The LORD told Jonah to take a message to the people of Nineveh but Jonah disobeyed

This section tells about the LORD's command to Jonah to preach a message of judgment and destruction to the people of Nineveh, the capital city of Assyria. Jonah, however, disobeyed the LORD and tried to flee from him; he got on a ship heading for Tarshish, a city in the opposite direction.

Paragraph 1:17

This verse is actually the first verse of chapter 2 in the Hebrew text. Some English translations also follow the Hebrew numbering system (NJB, NJPS). You should follow the numbering system of the national language translation used in your area.

1:17a

Now the LORD had appointed a great fish to swallow Jonah,

- ¶ As for Jonah, Yahweh prepared/sent/directed a huge fish to swallow him alive.

Now the LORD had appointed a great fish to swallow

Jonah: The form of the Hebrew verb *minneh* used here and translated appointed by BSB means "to appoint, ordain." This is an important word in the book of Jonah and shows that the LORD was in control over everything that happened to Jonah. Here is another way to translate this word:

At the Lord's command... (GNT)

a great fish: The Hebrew word translated as fish refers to creatures/animals that live in the sea. We are not told what kind of creature it was. Some have suggested that it may have been a whale, or a shark, or even a sea monster (Kleinert, p. 25). The important fact is that it was big enough to swallow Jonah alive and that he was inside it for three days and three nights.

1:17b

and Jonah spent three days and three nights in the belly of the fish.

- And Jonah stayed/was alive inside the fish for three days and three nights.

Jonah 2:1

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

Paragraph 2:1–2

When the sailors threw Jonah overboard into the sea, he thought he would drown. However, the large fish which the LORD sent swallowed him, so he was saved from the stormy sea.

2:1

From inside the fish, Jonah prayed to the LORD his God,

- ¶ While Jonah was inside the fish, he prayed to Yahweh his God,

From inside the fish, Jonah prayed to the LORD his God: Then Jonah prayed the following prayer thanking the LORD for rescuing him (even though he was not yet on dry land!).

his God: This does not mean Jonah owned God. It means the God whom Jonah served and worshiped. Depending on how you have chosen to translate “LORD,” there may be difficulties in translating this combined expression. See the discussion on LORD in the Introduction.

Jonah 2:2

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in

your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

Paragraph 2:1–2

When the sailors threw Jonah overboard into the sea, he thought he would drown. However, the large fish which the LORD sent swallowed him, so he was saved from the stormy sea.

2:2a

saying: “In my distress I called to the LORD,

- He said, “When I was in trouble and about to drown, I prayed to you^(sing), Yahweh,
- This is what he said; “O Yahweh, when I was in danger of dying/drowning, I called out to you^(sing),

In my distress I called to the LORD: Jonah had been in a dangerous situation, about to drown in the sea, so he had called to the LORD to rescue him from death.

distress: The word in Hebrew translated distress by the BSB means “distress, trouble.”

2:2b

and He answered me.

- and you^(sing) answered my prayer by helping me.
- and you^(sing) rescued me.

and He answered me: The LORD responded to Jonah’s cry for help and rescued him from death by providing a huge fish to swallow him.

Notice that in 2:2a–b Jonah first addressed the LORD in the third person He as if he were giving a testimony about his experience with the LORD. Then in 2:2d, Jonah switched to the second person “you (sing).” Alternating between the second and third person is a typical pattern in Hebrew, especially in poetry. In some languages this would not be natural or possible. The GNT has used only the second person 2:2 to make it clear that Jonah is addressing his prayer to the LORD. You may need to do the same thing.

2:2c

From the belly of Sheol I called for help,

- I was sure that I was about/going to die, so I called to you^(sing), Yahweh, to help me,
- My death seemed certain, so I cried out to you^(sing), Yahweh, to rescue me,

From the belly of Sheol I called for help: This is parallel to the expression “In my distress I called to the LORD” in 2:2a.

In my distress I called to the LORD

From the belly I called for help

of Sheol

It further describes the danger that Jonah was in as he was about to drown in the sea.

the belly of Sheol: The word Sheol often refers to the place of the dead. This does not mean that Jonah had actually died. The term Sheol (Hebrew šēʾōl) is often used in the Psalms to refer to immediate danger of death (Kleinert, p. 26). So by using this expression, Jonah was saying that he had felt sure that he was about to die. So he had called to the LORD to rescue him. Here is another way to translate this:

deep in the world of the dead (GNT)

I called for help: This is one word in Hebrew, a synonym for the word translated “called” in 2:2a.

2:2d

and You heard my voice.

- and you^(sing) heard my prayer.
- and you^(sing) listened to my cry for help.

and You heard my voice: This is parallel to “and He answered me” in 2:2b and means the same thing, that is, the LORD rescued Jonah when he cried to him for help.

Jonah 2:3

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:3a

For You cast me into the deep,

- ¶ You^(sing) had thrown me into the sea;

For You cast me into the deep: The events Jonah refers to in 2:3 happened before the events he refers to in 2:2: Jonah was first thrown into the sea and then he called for help.

It was of course the sailors who had thrown Jonah into the sea. However, Jonah acknowledged here that the LORD had caused them to do it.

2:3b

into the heart of the seas,

- you^(sing) had hurled me to the very bottom of the sea.

into the heart of the seas: This phrase is parallel to “the deep” in 2:3a. Both phrases refer to the deepest parts of the sea.

2:3c

and the current swirled about me;

- The water was swirling all around me,
- The water surrounded me,

and the current swirled about me: This continues the description of Jonah in the water. The Hebrew verb *saḥaḥ* which the BSB has translated swirled about means “surround, envelop.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the waters were all around me (GNT)

The floods engulfed me (NJPS)

2:3d

all Your breakers and waves swept over me.

- and I sank beneath the waves you^(sing) sent/commanded.
- and the waves you^(sing) sent spread over me.

all Your breakers and waves swept over me: This phrase is an exact quotation from Psalm 42:7. It is parallel to 2:3c. Jonah referred to the breakers and waves as belonging to the LORD. In this way he acknowledged that it was the LORD who had caused them.

breakers and waves: breakers are the rough waves which arrive at the shore or hit against rocks. If you have only one term for waves in your language, you could combine the two terms. For example:

mighty waves (GNT)

Jonah 2:4

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in

your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:4a

At this, I said, ‘I have been banished from Your sight;

- I thought, ‘O Yahweh, you^(sing) have sent me away from you.’
- I thought that you^(sing) had sent me away, out of your sight.
- I thought that you^(sing) had rejected me and sent me away from you.

I have been banished from Your sight: Here Jonah expressed what he said or thought as he was drowning. He felt that the LORD was no longer present with him and was no longer caring for him or protecting him (Keil-Delitzsch, p. 401). Notice that what Jonah said or thought in 2:4a–b can be expressed as either direct or indirect speech. (See the Display at 2:4a.) You need to decide which is most natural in your language. Using an indirect quote with the verb “thought,” as the GNT has done, suggests that this was what Jonah was thinking (or saying to himself) in the sea, rather than a prayer he was speaking.

2:4b

yet I will look once more toward Your holy temple.’

- Yet I dared to hope that it might/would be possible for me to see your holy temple once again.

yet I will look once more toward Your holy temple:

There is a textual problem with this part of the verse. The Hebrew text has the word *ʾak* which means “yet, surely.” However, scholars disagree about whether to translate this or to follow an alternative text which has *ʾeyk* “how.” So the English versions are divided and there are two choices:

1. Follow the Hebrew text which has the word *ʾak* “yet, surely.” In this case, this is an expression of hope and confidence that Jonah would once again see the LORD’s holy temple:

Yet/Surely I will once again look upon/toward your holy temple. (See BSB, NIV, KJV, NCV)2.4 Also supported by the LXX; Keil-Delitzsch, p. 401; Kleinert, p. 26.

1. Follow the one Greek manuscript which has read the word as *ʾeyk* “how.” In this case, Jonah’s expression is one of hopelessness: he thought he would never see the temple again:

How can I again look upon/toward your holy temple? (See GNT, CEV, GW, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV, REB)2.4 Ellison, p. 377; Stuart, p. 469.

Although a number of modern translations follow the second option, it has very little textual support. Therefore it is recommended that you follow the first option. Since many modern translations follow the second option, however, it is recommended that you refer to this option in a footnote.

Your holy temple: The term holy here refers to the fact that this temple is dedicated to the LORD for sacred purposes and belongs to him alone.

Scholars do not agree whether the temple mentioned here (2:4) and the temple mentioned in 2:7 referred to the temple in Jerusalem or to God’s dwelling place in heaven. Avoid referring to the location of the temple in these verses if possible. In both verses, the sense seems to be “the holy place where you (the LORD) live.”

Jonah 2:5

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:5a

The waters engulfed me to take my life;

- ¶ The waters engulfed me up to my neck,
- ¶ The sea rose around me up to my neck,

The waters engulfed me to take my life: The Hebrew for this is literally “waters surrounded me as far as my soul.” The Hebrew term *nepeš* has a number of possible meanings including “soul,” life, and “self.” Occasionally it can mean “neck, throat,” see Isaiah 5:14. This last meaning makes good sense here and a number of versions translate in a similar way to the NCV, which has:

“The waters of the sea closed around my throat” (NCV)

and Sasson (p. 182) who has:

“Water envelops me up to my neck.”

The important thing to express here is that Jonah was in a situation in which he was likely to die.

2:5b

the watery depths closed around me;

- and the waters of the sea surrounded me.
- and the water was all around me.

the watery depths closed around me: 2:5b is parallel to 2:5a. Jonah expressed the threat and danger of death that he felt as he found himself sinking deeper and deeper into the sea. Notice the parallelism:

The waters engulfed me to take my life;

the watery depths closed around me;

2:5c

the seaweed wrapped around my head.

- Seaweed was wrapped around my head.
- Sea plants were twisted round my head.

the seaweed wrapped around my head: Seaweed is a plant which grows on the bottom of the sea. It also floats freely in the sea and can wrap itself around people who are in the water. The Hebrew word used here is more general and can refer to any sort of plant which grows in water.

Jonah 2:6

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:6a

To the roots of the mountains I descended;

- As I went down to the very base of the mountains under the sea,

To the roots of the mountains I descended: As Jonah sank to the bottom of the sea, he settled at the roots (that is, base, foot) of the mountains under the sea.

I descended: This translates the normal Hebrew verb *yaraḏ* “to go down” and contrasts with the Hebrew *‘alah* “to go up” in 2:6c.

There are two possible ways of dividing this part of the verse:

1. Attach the phrase “I sank down” to the phrase “to the roots of the mountains.” This is the way the Hebrew text seems to be grouped and makes best sense of the grammar of the Hebrew, but it leaves 2:6b without a verb. (See BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NJPS, NJB, NLT) 2.6 Keil-Delitzsch, p. 401; Sasson, p. 167.
2. Place a sentence break after the word “mountains,” and in this way join the phrase “to the roots of the mountains” to 2:5c. The phrase I descended is then included in 2:6b. For example:

“weeds were wrapped around my head at the roots of the mountains. I went down to the land whose bars closed upon me forever; (RSV) (See JB, REB) 2.6 This view is supported by the LXX; Allen, p. 214.

It is recommended that you follow the first option like the majority of English versions.

2:6b

the earth beneath me barred me in forever!

- I felt as if I were a prisoner in the land of the dead, never to be released.
- to the land below where I thought I was shut in forever.

the earth beneath me barred me in forever!: At the very bottom of the sea, Jonah felt like he was in prison behind barred doors—without any chance of escape. Literally, the Hebrew says “the earth/land, its bars, behind me forever.” It is a clause without a verb, and English translations resolve this in different ways:

1. By supplying a verb from the noun “bars.” BSB has: barred me in. Here is another example:

closed upon me (NJPS)

1. By treating the clause as parallel to “at the roots of the mountains.” For example:

“I went down to the very roots of the mountains, into the land whose gates lock shut forever.” (GNT)

Either of these alternatives is acceptable.

the earth beneath me: This probably refers to “the land of the dead.” The GNT puts a footnote here to make this clear. Jonah was again saying that he had given up hope of living.

2:6c

But You raised my life from the pit, O LORD my God!

- But/Yet you^(sing) spared my life and rescued me from certain death, O Yahweh my God.
- But you^(sing), O Yahweh my God, spared my life and rescued me from dying and going to the place of the dead.

But You raised my life from the pit: The LORD rescued Jonah by having a huge fish swallow him alive. The expression You raised my life from the pit is Jonah’s way of saying that the LORD had spared his life when he was so close to death. The term pit is a synonym for šē’ol—the place of the dead^{2.6} Ellison, p. 377. See the note on 2:2c.

O LORD my God: Jonah addressed the LORD here as my God. This does not mean that he owned God. This is an expression of faith, that is, he referred to God in this way because he was the God whom he served and worshiped. See note on 2:1.

Notice that English versions place this phrase O LORD my God in different places in the sentence. For example, the BSB has it at the end of the sentence while the GNT puts it near the beginning. You should place it where it is most natural in your language.

Jonah 2:7

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:7a

As my life was fading away,

- Just before you^(sing) rescued me, when I was almost dead,
- When I was breathing my last breath,
- Just as I was losing consciousness,

As my life was fading away: The expression my life was fading away means that Jonah was almost dead. You may have some dramatic expression in your lan-

guage to express this. He was losing consciousness and his last conscious thought was of the LORD.

2:7b

I remembered the LORD.

- I thought of you^(sing), Yahweh, and prayed to you,

I remembered the LORD: As in 2:2a–b, Jonah first referred to the LORD in the third person here in 2:7b. Then in 2:7c he changed to second person “you^(sing).” As in 2:2, you need to decide what is natural in your language.

In the Hebrew text, the words translated the LORD have been placed at the front of the clause, probably for emphasis. This could be expressed in English as:

“it is the Lord whom I recalled.” (Sasson, p. 167)

2:7c

My prayer went up to You, to Your holy temple.

- and my prayer reached you^(sing), in the holy place where you live.
- and there in your holy temple, you^(sing) heard my prayer.

My prayer went up to You, to Your holy temple: This was Jonah’s way of saying that the LORD had heard his prayer.

Your holy temple: See note on 2:4b.

Jonah 2:8

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:8a

Those who cling to worthless idols

- ¶ Those who pay attention to idols which have no value
- ¶ I know that those who trust in worthless idols

Those who cling to worthless idols: In 2:8–9 Jonah contrasted himself, a believer in the true God, with people who worshiped idols. Jonah may have been referring to a particular group of people—for example, the sailors—or he may have been thinking about any-

one who worshiped idols rather than the true God^{2.8} Ellison, p. 387.

2:8b

forsake His loving devotion.

- will not be shown the grace you^(sing) wanted to show them.
- will not receive the kindness you^(sing) wanted to give them.

forsake His loving devotion: Literally “they forsake their grace.” This is a very difficult expression in Hebrew. Commentators and translations differ on how they interpret it, depending on how they translate *hesed*, which means “grace, kindness, loyalty, unfailing love,” and what they understand by the expression “their grace.”

The two main possibilities are:

1. “their grace” means “the LORD’s grace to them,” that is, the love and kindness which the LORD would have shown them if they had believed in him rather than worshipping idols. (BSB, NIV, CEV, JB, NLT)^{2.8} Allen, p. 215; Sasson, p. 167
2. “their grace” means “the loyalty which they should show to the LORD.” Here is another way to translate this:

have abandoned their loyalty to you (GNT) (RSV, GW, NCV, NET)^{2.8} Stuart, p. 478; Baldwin, p. 471.

There is good support for each of these possibilities. However, in the context, it seems as if Jonah was referring to the pagan sailors. From his point of view, as a Hebrew, people who were not Hebrews had never been “loyal” to the LORD, so how could they “have abandoned their loyalty to” him? The first interpretation makes more sense, therefore, and should be followed. Those who worship idols and follow them forsake the grace they might have obtained from the LORD.

Jonah 2:9

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:9a

But I, with the voice of thanksgiving, will sacrifice to You.

- But, as for me, I will make a sacrifice to you^(sing) with a song/prayer of thanksgiving.
- But I will thank you^(sing) with singing when I offer a sacrifice to you.

But I: In this verse Jonah contrasted himself and his behavior with those who worshiped idols (2:8). One way in English of showing this contrast is to begin the verse with “But as for me, I...”

with the voice of thanksgiving: It can refer to either spoken or sung praise. Hence CEV has “shouts of praise” instead of BSB’s voice of thanksgiving. Both are a kind of prayer.

will sacrifice to You: While Jonah thanked the LORD, he also intended to make a sacrifice to him. Exactly what the sacrifice would be is not mentioned, but, as in 1:16, the Hebrew verb used here usually refers to animal sacrifices.

2:9b

I will fulfill what I have vowed.

- The thing I have promised you^(sing) I will indeed do,
- I will indeed do what I promised you^(sing) that I would do.

I will fulfill what I have vowed: Here Jonah promised to fulfill the promise/vow he made to the LORD. He made this promise while he was still in the belly of the fish. He had not drowned, but now he needed to be delivered from inside the fish. The text does not tell us what Jonah promised to do. This is similar to the sailors’ reaction to their deliverance in 1:16.

2:9c

Salvation is from the LORD!

- Yahweh is the only source of deliverance/salvation/help.”
- It is Yahweh alone who saves/rescues.”

Salvation is from the LORD!: This statement declares that the LORD alone is able to save/rescue. Jonah was stating that the LORD was in control of the situation and could save him. Jonah again referred to the LORD in the third person (see 2:2 and 2:7). However, here it is probably best to keep the third person reference and consider that Jonah was making a statement about the LORD rather than addressing a remark to him. No major English version substitutes a second person reference here.

Jonah 2:10

Section 2:1–10: Jonah thanked the LORD for rescuing him

This section records the prayer that Jonah prayed after he was swallowed by the fish. Notice that the prayer is in the form of poetry. (Both BSB and GNT show this.) Therefore the structure of chapter two is very different from the other three chapters in Jonah, which are narrative material. If possible, try to translate the material in this chapter in a natural poetic form in your language. However, remember that the message is more important than the form in which it is written.

2:10

And the LORD commanded the fish, and it vomited Jonah onto dry land.

- ¶ Then after Jonah finished praying, Yahweh commanded/ordered/told the fish to vomit Jonah out of its belly onto the shore. And it did.
- ¶ Then Yahweh ordered the fish, “Vomit Jonah onto the shore.” And it did.

And the LORD commanded the fish, and it vomited Jonah onto dry land: The fish obeyed the LORD’s command and vomited Jonah onto the shore. In some languages, it may be necessary to use direct speech for the command (see the second meaning line in the Display of 2:10).

vomited: GNT uses the words “to spit” rather than vomited. However, remember that Jonah was in the belly of the fish and not in its mouth, so the concept of “to vomit” is probably more accurate.

dry land: We do not know where this occurred on the shore of the Mediterranean Sea, but you may need to specify that the dry land meant here was the beach or the shore.

Jonah 3:1

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:1

Then the word of the LORD came to Jonah a second time:

- ¶ Then Yahweh spoke again to Jonah,
- ¶ Then Yahweh again gave this command to Jonah,

Then the word of the LORD came to Jonah a second time: This verse is similar to 1:1. It begins the second major part of the book. The LORD once more commanded Jonah to go to Nineveh.

Jonah 3:2

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:2a

“Get up! Go to the great city of Nineveh

- “Go at once to the large city of/called Nineveh

Get up! Go to the great city of Nineveh: This part of the command is the same as the first time the LORD spoke to Jonah. See the note on 1:2a. You should translate it in the same way here.

3:2b

and proclaim to it the message that I give you.”

- and tell the people there what I tell you^(sing).”
- and give them the message of destruction which I tell you^(sing).”

and proclaim to it the message that I give you: This verse does not give the content of the message, but from the context (see 3:4), we know that it was a message of judgment and destruction.

Jonah 3:3

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:3a

This time Jonah got up and went to Nineveh, in accordance with the word of the LORD.

- ¶ So Jonah obeyed Yahweh’s command and went to Nineveh.
- ¶ This time Jonah did as Yahweh told him and went to Nineveh.

the word of the LORD: This expression should be translated in the same way as in 1:1 and 3:1.

3:3b**Now Nineveh was an exceedingly great city,**

- The city of Nineveh was very large.

an exceedingly great city: This translates a very difficult expression in Hebrew (literally “great to God”). There are two possible interpretations:

1. The phrase is a superlative, meaning “a very great city.” Most translations understand this in the sense of “large.”
2. The phrase may be understood in a more literal way such as “it was great in God’s eyes.” Some commentators prefer this interpretation and understand it to mean that God thought that Nineveh was important enough to send Jonah to it with a message.

Although the second interpretation makes sense in the context, no major English version has followed it, so it is recommended that you follow the first interpretation.

3:3c**requiring a three-day journey.**

- It took three days to walk through it.

requiring a three-day journey: The Hebrew here is literally “a walk/journey of three days.” This probably means that it took three days to go across it, or to make a visit to it. Since the main city of Nineveh was only 3 miles across, this description probably included the areas surrounding the city as well.

Jonah 3:4**Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed**

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:4a**On the first day of his journey, Jonah set out into the city**

- Jonah entered the city, and he walked through its streets for one day.
- When he arrived there, Jonah entered the city, and he walked through it for one day.

On the first day of his journey, Jonah set out into the city: Literally “Jonah began to enter the city going one day.” There are two ways of understanding the connection between this part of the verse and 3:4b:

1. 3:4a takes place before 3:4b, that is, Jonah did not begin announcing God’s message until he had walked through the city for a whole day—perhaps waiting until he reached the center of the city. (TEV, CEV, GW, NCV, NJB, NJPS, REB)
2. 3:4a and 3:4b take place more or less at the same time, that is, Jonah went through the city announcing God’s message as he walked. (BSB, NIV, NLT) 3.4 Stuart, p. 488; Sasson, p.231

Either is possible. The display follows the first interpretation.

3:4b**and proclaimed, “Forty more days and Nineveh will be overturned!”**

- Then he warned the people, “Forty days from now, Nineveh will be destroyed.”
- He announced to the people, saying, “God is going to destroy you^(plur) and your city in forty days.”
- He warned the people of Nineveh that God was going to destroy them and their city after forty days.

and proclaimed, “Forty more days and Nineveh will be overturned!”: Jonah announced to the people of Nineveh that they and their city were going to be destroyed in forty days.

You need to decide whether you should use direct or indirect speech here in your translation.

Nineveh: This refers not only to the city, but also to the people who lived there. You need to decide if you need to make this clear in your translation

Jonah 3:5**Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed**

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:5a**And the Ninevites believed God.**

- ¶ When the people of Nineveh heard this message from God, they believed what God had said.

And the Ninevites believed God: Scholars do not agree about how this should be translated. There are two possibilities:

1. It means they believed God’s message—that they understood that Jonah’s message was from God and that God was the one who would destroy them

and their city. (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, CEV, GW, KJV, NCV, NLT, REB)

2. It means that they believed in God. (NASB, NET, NJB).3.5 Keil-Delitzsch, p. 407; Sasson, p. 240

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), since it is supported by the majority of English versions as well as the context.

It may be necessary in your language to make it explicit that the people believed God as a result of hearing Jonah speak. Some possible ways of doing this are:

When the people of Nineveh heard what Jonah was saying to them, they believed what God was telling them.

The people of Nineveh believed the message from God which Jonah had preached to them.

3:5b

They proclaimed a fast

- So they decided that they must fast.
- So they said to each other, “We^(incl) must all refrain from eating and drinking.”

They proclaimed a fast: Because the people believed what God had told them, they decided they must try to avoid the disaster which he had threatened. The first thing they decided was that everyone should fast, that is, not eat or drink. The purpose of their fast was to show God that they had really repented.

proclaimed: The basic meaning of the Hebrew verb translated proclaimed is “call.” This probably means that this was not an official proclamation but something the people decided among themselves.

3:5c

and dressed in sackcloth, from the greatest of them to the least.

- Then all the people, from the least important to the most important, put on sackcloth to show that they had repented.
- Then all the people of the city, however important they were, dressed in sackcloth to show they had repented.

dressed in sackcloth, from the greatest of them to the least: Then all the people who had heard Jonah’s message put on sackcloth to show they had repented.

sackcloth: This was rough cloth, often made of goat’s hair. It was often worn when someone was mourning

the death of someone or, as here, to show they had repented of some act.

from the greatest of them to the least: This probably means “from the most important to the least important,” that is, everybody whoever they were. You should use an expression in your language which makes it clear that everyone was included.

Jonah 3:6

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:6a

When word reached the king of Nineveh,

- ¶ When the king of Nineveh heard what Jonah was announcing,

When word reached the king of Nineveh: The king of Nineveh heard about the message Jonah was announcing and he too believed that God was going to destroy the city in forty days.

3:6b

he got up from his throne,

- he got up from his throne,

he got up from his throne: The king got up from his throne, the special seat that a king sits on to show his authority.

3:6c

took off his royal robe, covered himself with sackcloth,

- he took off his official clothes/robes, and he dressed himself in sackcloth.

took off his royal robe, covered himself with sackcloth: He also took off his royal robes, which he wore to show he was king, and put on sackcloth like the ordinary people had done, to show that he too had repented.

sackcloth: See note on 3:5c.

3:6d

and sat in ashes.

- Then he sat on ashes scattered on the ground. He did all this to show he had repented.

and sat in ashes: It was a custom in that part of the world to sit on the ground in ashes to express sorrow. (See Job 2:13.)

Each of the actions in 3:6b–d was a sign that the king was repenting and humbling himself before God.

Jonah 3:7

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:7a

Then he issued a proclamation in Nineveh:

- Then he made a law to be proclaimed throughout the city of Nineveh. It said,
- Then he sent messengers everywhere in Nineveh to announce the following:

Then he issued a proclamation in Nineveh: Then the king made an official command and ordered messengers to announce it throughout the city. You may need to make these steps explicit in your translation. 3:7b–9 contain the content of the king’s command to the people.

3:7b

“By the decree of the king and his nobles:

- “I, the king and my officials have made the following command:
- “Here is the order of the king and his nobles:

By the decree of the king and his nobles: This was probably the way all important messages from the king began. The fact that it came from the king and his nobles gave authority to the message. It does not necessarily mean that the nobles had any part in making the decree, although perhaps they approved it.

decree: This is an official order or command from someone in authority. In this case, that person is the king.

nobles: These were the important men in the kingdom or city, perhaps the people who would advise the king on important issues. If your language has a word for “officials” you could use that. Another possibility is to use an expression like “important men.”

3:7c

Let no man or beast, herd or flock, taste anything at all. They must not eat or drink.

- It is forbidden for any person or animal, whether sheep, goat, or cow, to eat or drink anything.
- No person or animal, sheep, goat, or cattle, is allowed to eat or drink anything.
- Do not eat or drink anything. Do not let your^(plur) animals—sheep, goats, or cattle—eat or drink anything either.

Let no man or beast, herd or flock, taste anything at all. They must not eat or drink: The first part of the decree is the command not to eat or drink anything.

no man: This is the Hebrew word *ʾaḏam* and is not limited to males (as BSB might imply) It is the ordinary word for a human being of either sex. Here it means any person living in Nineveh.

or beast, herd or flock: Not only were people not allowed to eat and drink, but they were not to allow their animals to eat or drink, either.

beast: This word in Hebrew, *behemah*, is a general term and here refers to any domestic animal. Avoid using a word which might be understood to include wild animals.

herd or flock: The Hebrew word *baqar* translated herd refers to cattle. The Hebrew word *šׁon* translated flock refers to sheep and goats. These two terms are the normal way in Hebrew to group domestic animals.

Jonah 3:8

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:8a

Furthermore, let both man and beast be covered with sackcloth,

- Instead, everyone must dress himself in sackcloth to show that he has repented and put sackcloth on his animals.
- Dress yourselves^(plur) in sackcloth and put it on your animals, too.

Furthermore, let both man and beast be covered with sackcloth: Here again, the Hebrew word translated man is *ʾaḏam* and means a human being. Also, as mentioned in 3:7c, the Hebrew word *behemah* translated beast is a general term and refers to any domestic animal.

covered with sackcloth: In the Hebrew text, the same verb is used for people and animals covered with sackcloth. In your language, you may need to use two different verbs. For example:

“let the people wear sackcloth and the animals be covered in sackcloth.”

The king hoped that by including the animals in the fasting, and having them also covered in sackcloth, that God would no longer be angry with the people.

3:8b and have everyone call out earnestly to God.

- Each one of you^(plur) should pray earnestly to God for mercy.
- Cry loudly, all of you^(plur), to God and ask him to help/ save us^(incl).

and have everyone call out earnestly to God: The king also commanded the people to pray to God for mercy.

The Hebrew text here is literally “let them call upon God.” Take care that you do not use a pronoun here and in 3:8c which gives the impression that the king was ordering the animals to pray or turn from their evil behavior! The BSB has solved this problem by using the word everyone, which can only apply to people.

3:8c Let each one turn from his evil ways and from the violence in his hands.

- Everyone must stop doing evil and treating others violently.
- Stop behaving in such evil ways and harming others.

Let each one turn from his evil ways and from the violence in his hands: The king also ordered them to stop behaving in a wicked and violent way.

his evil ways: Literally, “their evil path,” that is, “their evil behavior.”

the violence in his hands: The Hebrew word translated the violence in his hands is not limited to physical injury but includes any wrong done to someone else. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

stop doing harm (NCV)

stop being...cruel (CEV)

Jonah 3:9

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:9a Who knows? God may turn and relent;

- If we^(incl) do that, perhaps God will change his mind
- Then maybe God will reconsider his plans,

Now the purpose of the decree is given. The king and his nobles hoped that God would notice that they had repented and would not destroy them.

Who knows?: This is a Hebrew idiom (as it is in English) that means that no one knows whether a certain thing will happen. Here are some other ways to translate this:

perhaps (GNT)

maybe (REB)

God may turn and relent: There are two problems with this part of the verse.

First, in Hebrew this expression contains two verbs: *šûb* “to turn” and *naḥam* “to be sorry, have compassion, repent.” There are two ways of understanding this double verb structure:

1. The two verbs should be translated as one single action. The second verb *naḥam* “to be sorry, have compassion, repent” is the main verb. The other verb *šûb*, literally “to turn,” is often used in Hebrew as an auxiliary verb with the meaning of “do something again.” This can be expressed in a translation by the word “again” or even omitted when the main verb already contains the idea of repeated action. For example:

change his mind (GNT)

reconsider his plans (GW) (RSV, CEV, NCV, NET, NLT, REB) 3.9 Sasson, p. 240 and Stuart, p. 494.

1. The two verbs represent two separate actions. For example:

relent and change his mind (NRSV)

turn and relent (NJPS) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NJB)3.9 See also Baldwin, p. 578.

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1) here. The verb *šub* is often used as an adverb in Hebrew, and the adverbial sense of “doing something again” fits well with the range of meaning of the second verb *naḥam*.

The second problem about which scholars and versions differ is the meaning of *naḥam* in this context. The two main possibilities are:

1. It should be translated “to change his mind, relent, repent”. (BSB, TEV, CEV, GW, KJV, NCV, NET, NJB, NJPS, NRSV, REB)3.9 Sasson, p. 240; Stuart, p.494
2. It should be translated “to have compassion, to be moved with pity”. (NIV, NLT)3.9 Baldwin, p. 578

Both are possible meanings of *naḥam* and both make sense in the context. However, the first meaning, “change his mind,” goes best with the use of *šub* as an auxiliary verb. Also these are the words of the pagan king of Nineveh, who had little knowledge of the compassionate God of Jonah. His interest was mainly in causing God to change his mind about destroying his city. For these reasons the first option is recommended (1).

3:9b

He may turn from His fierce anger,

- and stop being so angry with us^(incl)
- and his terrible anger against us^(incl) will stop

3:9c

so that we will not perish.”

- so we^(incl) will not die.”
- so he will not destroy us^(incl).”

Jonah 3:10

Section 3:1–10: The LORD again told Jonah to go to Nineveh and this time he obeyed

This section records how Jonah finally obeyed the LORD and went to Nineveh to preach to the people there. Then the people of Nineveh repented of their sinful ways and the LORD did not destroy them. An alternative title for this section could be: “The people of Nineveh repent.”

3:10a

When God saw their actions—

- ¶ When God saw that the people had repented

- ¶ When God saw what the people did to show they were sorry for the evil things they had done

3:10b

that they had turned from their evil ways—

- and that they had stopped doing the evil things they habitually did,

they had turned from their evil ways: This is the same expression as in 3:8c. See the note there.

3:10c

He relented from the disaster He had threatened to bring upon them.

- he changed his mind about destroying them as he had said he would, and he spared them.
- he reconsidered and did not destroy them as he had said he would.

He relented from the disaster He had threatened to bring upon them: The verb *naḥam*, which the BSB translates as relented, is the same verb discussed in the note in 3:9a, where the translation “to change one’s mind” was preferred. You should translate it in the same way here.

In the Hebrew, the verse ends with “and he (God) did not do it.” The BSB combines the ideas of changing one’s mind and of not doing something with the word relented. If it would make more sense in your language to separate those ideas you could follow the structure of, for example, the NRSV instead of the BSB. Here is another way to translate this:

God changed his mind about the calamity that he had said he would bring upon them; and he did not do it. (NRSV)

Jonah 4:1

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:1

Jonah, however, was greatly displeased, and he became angry.

- ¶ But Jonah was very indignant/irritated about this, and he became angry.
- ¶ Since Yahweh did not fulfill his threat to destroy the city/people of Nineveh, Jonah was very indignant and angry.
- ¶ This was absolutely disgusting to Jonah, and he became angry.

Jonah, however, was greatly displeased, and he became angry: When Jonah saw that the LORD had not destroyed Nineveh, he was not pleased. In fact, he was very angry about it.

Jonah, however, was greatly displeased: This expression is literally “it was evil to Jonah with great evil.” This is a strong expression in Hebrew. If you must translate in a way that says that Jonah was unhappy, make it clear in your statement that Jonah was extremely (very) upset. One translation is “this was absolutely disgusting to Jonah” (Stuart, p. 498). Here is another translation:

This made Jonah very indignant (NJB)

Jonah 4:2**Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion**

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:2a

So he prayed to the LORD,

- So he prayed/complained to Yahweh,

4:2b

saying, “O LORD, is this not what I said while I was still in my own country?”

- “O Yahweh, even when I was still in my own country, I knew that this is what would happen if I came here and proclaimed your^(sing) message to these people.

- “Even before I left my own country, O Yahweh, is this not the very thing I said/knew you^(sing) would do if I obeyed you?

is this not what I said while I was still in my own country?: Jonah told the LORD that this was just what he expected to happen. He had feared that if he went to preach to the people of Nineveh, they might repent of their evil ways and the LORD would not destroy them.

This is a rhetorical question; Jonah was complaining. If you cannot use rhetorical questions in your language when you complain about something, you will need to use a statement instead. See 4:2b in the Display for examples of both options.

while I was still in my own country: Here Jonah was referring to his home country, Israel.

4:2c

This is why I was so quick to flee toward Tarshish.

- That is why I tried to run away from you^(sing) and go to Tarshish instead.
- That is why I was in such a hurry to flee in the opposite direction to Tarshish.

This is why I was so quick to flee toward Tarshish:

Since Jonah wanted Israel’s enemies to be destroyed, he did not want the LORD to spare Nineveh. So rather than give them the chance to repent, he ran away to Tarshish.

4:2d

I knew that You are a gracious and compassionate God,

- For I knew that you^(sing) are a kind and merciful God,
- Because I knew that you^(sing) are kind and compassionate,

I knew that You are a gracious and compassionate

God: In Hebrew, this part of the verse begins with the connecting word *kiy* “for.” Although the BSB and a number of other versions have omitted it, it is an important connection. Jonah ran away because he knew God was kind and would forgive the people of Nineveh if they believed God’s message through Jonah and repented from their sins. You should make sure this relationship is clear in your translation.

a gracious and compassionate God: The two adjectives used here, *ḥannun* (gracious) and *raḥum* (compassionate), are usually only used to refer to God.

gracious: This means that God is kind to those who are evil and who are his enemies. Because he is gracious, he treats them with kindness even though such people do not deserve such treatment from him.

compassionate: This means that God shows pity to those who suffer and is merciful to those who do not deserve mercy.

4:2e

slow to anger,

- you^(sing) are slow to become angry,
- you^(sing) do not get angry quickly with people,

slow to anger: The Hebrew expression here has two aspects: first, someone who does not get angry easily or quickly, and, second, someone who is even-tempered and patient (UBS Handbook, p. 105). Since there is no English word that includes both aspects in its meaning, English versions handle this expression in two ways:

1. They emphasize “not getting angry quickly”. This can be expressed positively as “slow to get angry,” or negatively as “not quick to get angry.” (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT)4.2 Baldwin, p. 582
2. They emphasize “being patient”. (TEV, CEV, GW)4.2 Stuart, p. 498; Sasson, p. 270

It is recommended that you follow the first option, unless your term for “patient” includes the idea of someone who doesn’t get easily angered.

4:2f

abounding in loving devotion—

- and your^(sing) unfailing love is great.
- and you^(sing) never stop showing great love to people.
- and your^(sing) love is great and continues forever.

abounding in loving devotion: The Hebrew word translated here as loving devotion is *hesed*. See how you translated the same word in 2:8b. This word often contains the meaning, “faithfulness, loyalty, steadfastness.” Here are some other ways to translate this word:

steadfast love (RSV)

loyal love (NET)

unfailing love (NLT)

The same list of God’s attributes in 4:2d–f, that is, “gracious,” “compassionate,” “slow to anger,” and “abounding in loving devotion,” is also found in Exodus 34:6, Nehemiah 9:17, Psalm 86:15, Psalm 103:8, Psalm 145:8, and Joel 2:13.

4:2g

One who relents from sending disaster.

- You^(sing) are a God who can change your mind about destroying people.
- You^(sing) are a God who does not want to destroy people.

One who relents from sending disaster: This aspect of God’s character is not found in the other lists mentioned above because it is specific to Jonah’s situation.

relents from sending disaster: This is literally “changes his mind about the evil” and is the same expression as was found in 3:10c. They should be translated the same way in both places.

relents: This verb is again *naḥam*. See the discussion on this verb in 3:9a.

The idea that the LORD could change his mind and not destroy people was not a comforting thought to Jonah because he had hoped that the LORD would destroy the people of Nineveh.

Jonah 4:3

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:3a

And now, O LORD, please take my life from me,

- So, O Yahweh, let me die!

4:3b

for it is better for me to die than to live.”

- For I would rather die than go on living.”
- That would be better for me than to go on living.”

4:3a–b

And now, O LORD, please take my life from me, for it is better for me to die than to live: Jonah became so angry that he asked the LORD to let him die. He preferred to die than live and see the LORD be merciful to his enemies, the people of Nineveh.

And now: The word translated And now is not used in the sense of “At this minute” here, and you should avoid using a word in your language which would give this impression. This expression in Hebrew indicates that what follows is Jonah’s conclusion based on what he said in 4:2, that is, if God was going to spare the people of Nineveh, Jonah would prefer to be dead. In English And now can have this function, but other versions use words that more directly introduce conclusions. For example:

So (GW)

Therefore (RSV)

Jonah 4:4

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:4a

But the LORD replied,

- But Yahweh answered him,

4:4b

“Have you any right to be angry?”

- “Are you^(sing) right to be angry?”
- “What right do you^(sing) have to be angry?”
- “You^(sing) have no right to be angry.”

Have you any right to be angry?: God replied to Jonah’s protest and request to die with a rhetorical question. God was saying that Jonah had no right to be angry about the outcome of the situation or the way the LORD had acted.

Jonah 4:5

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about

it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:5a

Then Jonah left the city and sat down east of it,

- ¶ Jonah left the city and went toward the east to a place where he could overlook the city.

Then Jonah left the city and sat down east of it:

Jonah had left Nineveh, but he only went a short distance from it. Since there were mountains in that direction, Jonah was able to survey the city from the place he had gone to^{4.5} Keil-Delitzsch, p. 412.

4:5b

where he made himself a shelter and sat in its shade

- He made a shelter/hut for himself there and sat in its shade.

where he made himself a shelter and sat in its shade:

The word translated shelter here is the same word used in Leviticus 23:42–43 for the “(Feast of) Tabernacles.” If you have a word in your language for a temporary shelter constructed in the fields to shelter workers from the sun or to use when guarding the harvest, that would fit well here.

4:5c

to see what would happen to the city.

- He sat there waiting to see what would happen to the city.

to see what would happen to the city: This probably means that Jonah was hoping that the LORD would once more change his mind and destroy the city as he first threatened to do^{4.5} Stuart, p. 504.

Jonah 4:6

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was

upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:6a

So the LORD God appointed a vine, and it grew up

- Then Yahweh God made a leafy plant sprout up and grow

the LORD God appointed a vine: This phrase means that God caused a plant to grow. The Hebrew verb *minneh* used here is the same one that was translated appointed in 1:17a. There the LORD provided a great fish to save Jonah, now he provided a plant to shelter him. The rapid growth of this plant indicates that this was miraculous.

the LORD God: In the book of Jonah, God is usually called the LORD (Yahweh) or God (*‘elohim*), although in chapter 2 he is called “the LORD his God” and “the LORD my God.” Here the two names for God are joined together without any pronoun. The use of LORD God without a possessive pronoun is fairly rare in the OT. It is found mainly in Genesis 2–3 and in 1 and 2 Chronicles. How you translate this phrase will depend on the term you have chosen for Yahweh. See the note in the Introduction.

vine: The word translated vine by BSB4.6 See also the NIV; CEV only occurs in this passage in the OT and no one has been able to identify for certain what sort of plant is being referred to. So most English versions translate it as “plant”4.6 See TEV, RSV, GW, NCV, NET. You should use as generic a term as possible for “plant” in your translation here rather than using the name of a specific plant from your area which possibly did not grow in Nineveh. The important thing about this plant is that it was leafy and provided enough shade to protect Jonah’s head and to ease the discomfort he was experiencing from the hot sun. This made Jonah very happy.

4:6b

to provide shade over Jonah’s head to ease his discomfort,

- over Jonah’s head to shelter him from the sun and make him less uncomfortable.

4:6c

and Jonah was greatly pleased with the plant.

- Jonah was delighted because of the plant.

- Jonah was very pleased because the plant was there to shelter him from the sun.

Jonah 4:7

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:7a

When dawn came the next day, God appointed a worm

- ¶ However, the next day at dawn, God sent a worm,

4:7b

that attacked the plant so that it withered.

- which chewed the stem/root of the plant and caused it to wither.
- which gnawed on the stem/root of the plant so that it died.

4:7a–b

When dawn came the next day, God appointed a worm that attacked the plant so that it withered:

Jonah’s relief only lasted one day, because the next day God sent a worm which chewed the vine so that it withered and died. Then there was no longer enough shade to protect Jonah from the burning sun.

God appointed a worm: The Hebrew verb *minneh* translated here as appointed is the same word as in 1:17a and 4:6a. See the notes on those verses. The same verb also occurs in 4:8a. In each case God “provided” something which affected Jonah. In all four verses the BSB uses appointed. If you can use the same verb in the four verses, you should do so. The important thing in each case was that God initiated the action and was in control.

worm: Scholars have suggested a number of possible translations for the Hebrew term translated worm in the BSB and most other English versions. Some other suggestions are: larva, maggot, weevil, beetle, or centipede4.7 Sasson, p. 301. If possible, use a general

word for this creature, one that refers to something that eats stems or leaves.

Jonah 4:8

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:8a

As the sun was rising, God appointed a scorching east wind,

- When the sun rose, God sent/caused a very hot wind to blow from the east,

appointed: This is the final use of this Hebrew verb *minneh* in Jonah. See the notes on 1:17a, 4:6a, 4:7a.

scorching: This a difficult word to understand in Hebrew, but most translations have something like “burning” or “hot,” which makes good sense in the context.

4:8b

and the sun beat down on Jonah’s head so that he grew faint

- and the sun beating down on Jonah’s head caused him to feel faint.
- and Jonah felt faint as the sun blazed down on his head.

the sun beat down on Jonah’s head so that he grew faint: Without the shelter of the plant, Jonah had little protection from the sun. So both the burning sun and the hot wind were causing him severe discomfort.

the sun beat down on Jonah’s head: Many languages have an idiom to describe the burning action of the sun on someone’s head. If you have such an expression in your language, you could use it here.

he grew faint: This expression may convey the idea of suffering sunstroke. Keil-Delitzsch, p. 415.

4:8c

and wished to die, saying,

- So he wished he were dead and said to God,

wished to die, saying: Again Jonah expressed a wish to die. In 4:3, his reason was his distress and anger because the LORD had spared the people of Nineveh rather than destroying them as he had threatened. Now, he was also experiencing physical discomfort from the sun.

4:8d

“It is better for me to die than to live.”

- “I would rather die than go on living.”
- “It would be better for me to die than to go on living.”

It is better for me to die than to live: Notice that Jonah used the same words here as in 4:3b.

Jonah 4:9

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

4:9a

Then God asked Jonah,

- But God said to him,

4:9b

“Have you any right to be angry about the plant?”

- “Are you^(sing) right to be angry about this plant which withered?”
- “What right do you^(sing) have to be angry because of what happened to this plant?”
- “You^(sing) have no right to be angry just because this plant/vine has withered.”

Have you any right to be angry about the plant?:

Once again God scolded Jonah for his anger. This is another rhetorical question and implied that Jonah did not have the right to be angry.

4:9c

“I do,” he replied. “I am angry enough to die!”

- Jonah said, “Yes I am right to be angry. I am so angry that I want to die.”
- Jonah replied, “I do have a right to be angry! I am so angry about what has happened to this plant that I wish I were dead.”

“I do,” he replied. “I am angry enough to die!”: Jonah, however, insisted that he was indeed right to be angry because the plant had withered.

angry enough to die!: This phrase can have two meanings: First, it means that Jonah was so angry that he actually preferred death to life. And secondly, it is an idiom to show that Jonah was very angry.^{4.9} UBS Handbook, p. 112

Jonah 4:10

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

Paragraph 4:10–11

The LORD wanted Jonah to see that his attitude towards the people of Nineveh was not reasonable. If Jonah could care about a plant which he never looked after or caused to grow, then was it not right that the LORD should care about the people of Nineveh, whom he created and whom he loved?

4:10a

But the LORD said,

- ׀ But Yahweh said to him,

4:10b

“You cared about the plant,

- “You^(sing) felt compassion for this plant
- “You^(sing) felt sorry about what happened to this plant

4:10a-b

You cared about the plant: The Hebrew verb *h*us which the BSB has translated cared about really means “to pity, to look on with compassion.” It is the same verb which God uses in 4:11a for his emotions

regarding the people of Nineveh. If it is not possible in your language to say “have compassion for the plant” (NET), or “feel sorry for it [the plant]” (TEV), you could say “felt sorry about what happened to the plant.”

4:10c

which you neither tended nor made grow.

- even though you^(sing) did not make it grow or care for it.

4:10d

It sprang up in a night and perished in a night.

- It was only a plant which grew up one night and died the next night.

4:10c-d

It sprang up in a night and perished in a night:

The rapid growth of the plant shows that this was a miraculous event. The fact that the plant only lived a short time seems to emphasize the fact that it really was not as important as Jonah thought it was.

Jonah 4:11

Section 4:1–11: The LORD showed Jonah his mercy and compassion

Jonah was upset that the LORD had not destroyed the people of Nineveh, and he argued with the LORD about it. The LORD taught Jonah that Jonah, too, should have compassion on the people of Nineveh. The LORD caused a plant to grow to shelter Jonah from the sun and then sent a worm to destroy it. When Jonah was upset about the plant being destroyed, the LORD told him that if he could be concerned about a mere plant, it was more fitting that the LORD should be concerned about people—as people are more important to him than plants. This was to show Jonah how much the LORD cared about people—even the enemies of the Israelites.

Paragraph 4:10–11

The LORD wanted Jonah to see that his attitude towards the people of Nineveh was not reasonable. If Jonah could care about a plant which he never looked after or caused to grow, then was it not right that the LORD should care about the people of Nineveh, whom he created and whom he loved?

4:11a

So should I not care about the great city of Nineveh,

- So, is it not right that I should show compassion for the huge city Nineveh and all its inhabitants?
- Similarly, it is proper that I be concerned about that huge city, Nineveh, and all its inhabitants.”

So should I not care about the great city of Nineveh:

The book ends with another rhetorical question to which the implied answer is “Yes, I [the LORD] am right to have compassion for the people in Nineveh.” If you cannot use rhetorical questions in this way in your language, you can use a statement instead. See 4:11d in the Display.

care about: This is the same Hebrew verb *h*us as in 4:10b. See the comments there. You should translate the verb in the same way in the two verses.

4:11b**which has more than 120,000 people**

- Are not its people more valuable than that plant? Yes they are! And there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand (120,000) of them,
- Then Yahweh added, “There are more than a hundred and twenty thousand people in the city, and they are more valuable than that plant,

4:11c**who cannot tell their right hand from their left,**

- people who cannot even distinguish evil from good.

4:11b-c

which has more than 120,000 people who cannot tell their right hand from their left: Here the LORD contrasted Jonah’s compassion for an insignificant plant with his own compassion for the people of Nineveh. If Jonah could feel compassion for a plant, which only lived a day, it was even more fitting that the LORD should have compassion on the people of Nineveh, who were much more important.

more than 120,000 people who cannot tell their right hand from their left: Scholars do not agree about to whom this refers. The two possibilities are:

1. This refers to all the people living in Nineveh. In this case the expression who cannot tell their right hand from their left is a Hebrew idiom which means that the people cannot tell right from wrong. (NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, NCV, NJB, REB)^{4.11} Allen, p. 230; Baldwin, p. 590; Ellison, p. 389; Sasson, p. 300; Stuart, p. 507
2. This refers only to the small children living in Nineveh, children too young to be able to tell their right hand from their left hand. (TEV)^{4.11} Keil-Delitzsch, pp. 416–17; UBS Handbook, pp. 114–15

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), as do the majority of English versions and commentaries.

Some versions make explicit the meaning of the Hebrew idiom who cannot tell their right hand from their left. For example, NCV has:

which has more than one hundred twenty thousand people who do not know right from wrong (NCV)

You need to decide whether you should do the same or keep the literal expression with perhaps a footnote to explain its meaning.^{4.11} See also CEV

4:11d**and many cattle as well?”**

- Not only that, but there are also many animals there as well.”

and many cattle as well: God not only had compassion on the people of Nineveh, he also had compassion on the animals and spared them as well.

cattle: The Hebrew word *behemah* which the BSB translates as cattle can also be a general term for domestic animals and is not limited to cattle.^{4.11} See also GW, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, NRSV. Here is a more general way to translate this word:

animals (GNT)

General Comment about 4:11

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 4:11, so that God’s statement about the size of the city comes before his rhetorical question about his concern for them. One model for this would be the NIV:

But Nineveh has more than a hundred and twenty thousand people who cannot tell their right hand from their left, and many cattle as well. Should I not be concerned about that great city? (NIV)